

- RAG Learning

2.10 Comparative — The Executives

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 2 (Government and Politics of the USA and Comparative Politics)

Comparing the UK Prime Minister with the US President is the most common comparative essay on Paper 2 — and the most commonly answered badly, because students try to decide which is "more powerful" overall. The correct answer is that each is more powerful in **different dimensions**, and the dimensions run in opposite directions.

1. Side by side

	UK Prime Minister	US President
Selection	Leader of the party commanding a Commons majority; not separately elected	Separately elected via the Electoral College
Relationship to legislature	Fused — sits in and is drawn from Parliament	Separate — does not sit in Congress
Term	No fixed term; no term limit	Fixed four years; maximum two terms (22nd Amendment)
Removal	By their own party at any time, or by losing Commons confidence	Only by impeachment and conviction (2/3 Senate), or for incapacity under the Twenty-Fifth Amendment — neither has ever removed a President
Veto	None — does not need one	Yes; overridable by 2/3 of both chambers
Head of state	No — the monarch	Yes — combined with head of government

Cabinet	Collective body of parliamentarians; can end a premiership	Individually appointed advisers; cannot remove the President except, with the Vice-President, for incapacity under the Twenty-Fifth Amendment (never used)
Legislative success	Near-automatic with a secure majority	Frequently fails, even under unified government
Unilateral powers	Royal prerogative — deployment, treaties, appointments, election timing (since 2022)	Executive orders, executive agreements, signing statements, pardon

2. Structural analysis

Why a President struggles to legislate

- **Separation of powers** — separately elected, with no guaranteed legislative majority; divided government has been the norm for much of the post-war period.
- **Multiple veto points** — the House, the Senate, the filibuster's effective 60-vote threshold, and judicial review. The President controls none directly.
- **Weak party discipline** — even under unified government, legislators nominated in primaries and funding their own campaigns may defy the President without penalty. Obama's difficulties passing the ACA despite Democratic control of both chambers illustrate this.

Why a Prime Minister legislates almost automatically

Fusion of powers. The PM is Prime Minister *because* they command a Commons majority. With the whips, the payroll vote and control of the timetable, with the Lords able only to delay for a year, and with no court able to strike the resulting statute down, legislation is close to guaranteed.

Exam Tip: The **veto is evidence of presidential weakness, not strength** — a counter-intuitive point that marks out a strong answer. A PM needs no veto because a PM who

opposes a bill simply prevents it from being introduced. The President needs one precisely because Congress can legislate without them.

3. The reversal: security of tenure

Everything above suggests the PM is more powerful. Tenure reverses it completely.

- A **President cannot be removed** for unpopularity, for losing legislative votes, or by their party. Only impeachment and conviction (two-thirds of the Senate) — or, for incapacity, the **Twenty-Fifth Amendment** (the Vice-President plus a cabinet majority, sustained by two-thirds of both chambers) — can end the term early, and *neither has ever removed a President*. They can therefore pursue unpopular policies and outlast poor polling.
- A **Prime Minister holds office only while their party permits it**, and both main parties can remove a leader at any time. **Thatcher (1990), May (2019), Johnson (2022) and Truss (2022) all left office without losing a general election.**

Exam Tip: This is the single most important comparative fact in the topic, and it has **no US parallel whatsoever**. It also explains a behavioural difference: a weakened PM is *removed*, whereas a weakened President simply governs by executive order until the term expires. That is why UK premierships end abruptly and failing presidencies limp on.

4. Rational analysis

- **Why US legislators defy their own President.** They win nomination in primaries, raise their own money, and cannot be deselected by the national party. The career risk is a primary challenge from the ideological flank, not presidential displeasure — so supporting an unpopular President can cost them their seat while defying one costs nothing.
- **Why UK MPs rarely rebel.** They depend on the party for selection, for the label that delivers most of their vote, and for promotion, which the whips influence. Rebellion risks deselection and ends ministerial prospects. Fusion raises the stakes further: a major rebellion can bring down the government and trigger an election that costs them their seat.

- **Why PMs appoint rivals to cabinet.** Dangerous figures are safer inside the government, bound by collective responsibility, than outside it — a rational calculation that is itself evidence of constraint operating before any appointment is made.

5. Cultural analysis

- **Personalisation of the presidency** — combining head of state and head of government gives the office a symbolic national role drawing on American patriotic tradition, which no PM commands. The President embodies the nation in a way the UK deliberately separates into the monarchy.
- **American individualism** — a tradition of suspicion towards centralised authority supports a politics in which legislators build personal followings and are rewarded for independence.
- **British party government** — a parliamentary tradition in which voters choose a programme and a party rather than an individual, supporting disciplined collective government.

6. Similarities

- Both are **head of government**, directing national policy, representing the country abroad and commanding the armed forces.
- Both have **grown more powerful** over the twentieth century — the expansion of the state, the demands of war and crisis, and media focus on a single national leader.
- Both can **act unilaterally** without new legislation — executive orders and the royal prerogative are functionally comparable.
- Both have seen those unilateral powers **constrained by the courts** — *Miller I* and *Miller II*; *Youngstown* (1952), *DHS v Regents* (2020, blocking the DACA rescission) and *Biden v Nebraska* (2023, striking down student-loan cancellation). The travel ban is a counter-example: the Supreme Court upheld it in *Trump v Hawaii* (2018).
- Both depend on large personal staff organisations — EXOP and the PM's Office — which have grown substantially.
- Both face their weakest checks in **foreign and security policy**.

7. Are both "imperial"?

Imperial presidency (Schlesinger)	Presidentialisation of the premiership (Foley)
War without declarations since 1942; executive orders and agreements; executive privilege; surveillance	Personalised mandates and leaders' debates; "sofa government"; growth of the centre; spatial leadership
Counter: routine legislative failure, midterm losses, reversed orders, impeachments	Counter: tenure is conditional; no veto; no personal mandate; cabinet can end a premiership

Exam Tip: The strongest unified conclusion: **both executives appear imperial chiefly in foreign and security policy**, where legislative checks are weakest in each system, and both face real constraints their critics understate domestically. But the constraints differ in kind — the President is constrained by *other institutions*, the PM by *their own party*.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Fusion of powers	Executive drawn from and sitting in the legislature (UK)
Separation of powers	Separate institutions with separate personnel (USA)
Divided government	Presidency and at least one chamber held by different parties
Executive order	Presidential directive with the force of law, requiring no congressional approval
Royal prerogative	Residual Crown powers exercised by UK ministers without statutory authority
Collective responsibility	UK convention binding ministers to support government decisions or resign

Imperial presidency	Schlesinger's thesis of presidential power escaping constitutional limits
Presidentialisation	Foley's thesis that the premiership has acquired presidential characteristics
Lame duck	An executive whose authority is draining as their term ends

Essential examples

- **Thatcher 1990, May 2019, Johnson 2022, Truss 2022** — four PMs removed without losing an election; no US parallel.
- **ACA repeal failure 2017** — a President defeated under unified government.
- **May's 230-vote defeat, 2019** — a PM weaker than most presidents.
- **DACA / Iran deal / Paris accord** — executive action reversed by successors.
- **Miller I and II vs *Youngstown*** — courts constraining unilateral executive power in both systems.
- **2013 Syria vote** — the Commons blocking military action; the War Powers Resolution rarely achieving the same.
- **Trump 2025–** — unified Republican control; over 200 executive orders in 2025; *Trump v United States* (2024) immunity; *Trump v CASA* (2025) curbing nationwide injunctions against executive action. But the Court struck down his emergency-power tariffs in *Learning Resources v Trump* (2026), 6–3.
- **Starmer 2025** — despite a 411-seat majority, a backbench rebellion forced the government to gut its welfare bill (July 2025); even a landslide PM is constrained by party.